



Strategic Delay Mitigation

Customer-focused solutions to drive operational sustainability

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Fact Pack

Client

United Airlines stands as one of the four primary leaders in the U.S. airline industry sector, operating the largest mainline fleet in the world with a route network that is the most comprehensive in North America¹. Driven by its vision of connecting people and uniting the world, United strives for a level of operational excellence that allows it to provide “a level of service to our customers that makes us a leader in the airline industry”².

Furthermore, United strives to maintain a “growing, reliable operation” supported by record investments in technology and infrastructure. This commitment to innovation and growth is reflected in its “United Next” strategy, a large-scale modernization plan that has includes an order for 750 new aircraft to replace older fleet members.

Challenge

As United pursues its high-asset utilization “United Next” strategy, it encounters a tradeoff between scheduling a revenue-maximizing number of flights and avoiding flight delays at core hubs. This dilemma is exacerbated by United’s need to generate enough revenue to pay off its massive investments in 750 new aircraft, 25,000 new employees, and more throughout the course of the initiative³. Ultimately, United must find a way to balance its revenue-maximization with customer satisfaction and brand loyalty.

¹ [United Airlines - Strategic Analysis and Outlook Report \(2026\)](#)

² [Our United Customer Commitment](#)

³ [United Adds 270 Boeing and Airbus Aircraft to Fleet, Largest Order in Airline's History and Biggest by a Single Carrier in a Decade - Jun 29, 2021, United Airlines plans mega fleet expansion with 250+ planes, United Airlines Expects to Hire 25,000 People by 2026 After Massive Jetliner Order – NBC Bay Area](#)

Goal

United's ultimate goal is to provide "a level of service to our customers that makes us a leader in the airline industry"⁴. In other words, United must bridge the gap between financial growth and customer satisfaction by implementing customer-focused solutions that address their concerns and lower costs for United.

Three Questions Consultants Should Always Ask

Who is the customer?

United serves a large variety and volume of customers. While "United Next" is a premiumization strategy, United serves passengers with varying economic situations from all over the world. Ultimately, behind each booking and transaction is a person, who might be flying to her daughter's wedding, a business meeting, a family vacation, or to help with the birth of her first grandchild.

What value am I creating for the customer?

United Airlines connects the world, enabling people to travel anywhere in the world so that they can be present at life's most meaningful and important events, wherever they may be. By developing and implementing a solution that directly mitigates the effects of flight delays, United ensures that their passengers not only reach their destinations but receive quality support through a seamless travel experience.

⁴ [Our United Customer Commitment](#)

What value am I capturing?

The value captured by implementing solutions to mitigate delays is twofold: 1) United can create positive brand value, allowing its customer satisfaction scores to rise above those of its competitors, and 2) United can recapture the revenue that is lost with the massive financial costs that each delay incurs on the airline (~\$100.07 per minute)⁵. With both of these goals achieved, United will be able to more effectively run the largest commercial airplane fleet in the world, capturing incremental market share and further closing the gap with its competitors.

Information Tree

Strategy

- What is our position in the domestic market (and is it differentiated)?
 - United Airlines holds a commanding position in the U.S. airline industry, though the competitive dynamics among legacy carriers remain intense (Source: [United Airlines - Strategic Analysis and Outlook Report \(2026\)](#)).
 - Despite ranking fourth in domestic market share, United operates the largest mainline fleet of any airline worldwide with 1,055 aircraft. The airline's 5.7% domestic capacity growth in 2025 significantly exceeds competitors' growth rates, positioning United to capture incremental market share through 2026 (Source: [United Airlines - Strategic Analysis and Outlook Report \(2026\)](#)).

⁵ [U.S. Passenger Carrier Delay Costs | Airlines For America](#)

Airline	Domestic Market Share (Sept 2024 - Aug 2025)	Competitive Position
American Airlines	21%	Largest by market share
Delta Air Lines	19-21%	Co-leader with premium focus
Southwest Airlines	18%	Low-cost carrier leader
United Airlines	16%	Fourth by share, but largest fleet globally

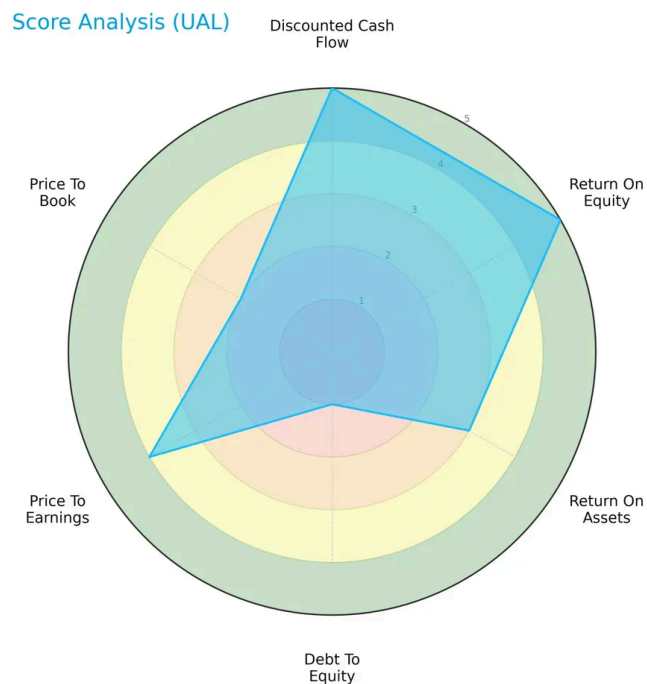
Source: [United Airlines - Strategic Analysis and Outlook Report \(2026\)](#)

- The sector includes 3 competitors, with the table listing the top 3 leaders by market capitalization:

Competitor	Market Cap.
Delta Air Lines, Inc.	45B
United Airlines Holdings, Inc.	36.6B
Southwest Airlines Co.	21.4B

Source: [Is United Airlines Facing Execution Risk? A 2026 Review](#)

- What are our organization's priorities (and what should we not do)?
 - “We are committed to providing a level of service to our customers that makes us a **leader in the airline industry**. We understand that to do this we need to have a **product we are proud of and employees who like coming to work every day**.



Source: [Is United Airlines Facing Execution Risk? A 2026 Review](#)

Operations

- What is the current state of operations?
 - “Customers continue to benefit from United's growing, reliable operation. United canceled flights at the lowest per-seat rate among U.S. network

airlines in 2025 while flying the largest mainline schedule in the airline's history, carrying an average of more than 496,000 passengers daily. United's 303 daily widebody departures in 2025 were the most in its history. United Express logged 134 days without a single cancellation during 2025, and Connection Saver saved more than one million potential missed connections during the year, a 42% increase over 2024.” (Source: [United Airlines Q4 and Full Year EPS Beat Wall Street Expectations. With Full Year EPS Up Year-Over-Year](#))

- How do we deliver our business model?
 - Achieved its best November NPS ever, despite the government shutdown. For the full year, United achieved its highest NPS since 2022 among on-time passengers, including a seven-point increase in the check-in experience thanks to United's investments in the lobby experience, **improved kiosks and the United mobile app**.
 - In May, announced United's Blue Sky collaboration with JetBlue, and launched the ability to book across both airlines with miles in October 2025, with the ability to book with money expected in early 2026.
 - United announced its new MileagePlus Debit Rewards Card in November, offering additional ways to earn miles through spending and saving.
 - Launched a collaboration with ride-share app Lyft in the fourth quarter, allowing MileagePlus members to earn up to four miles per dollar spent on eligible rides.
 - During 2025, United **enhanced its app with new features** including a bag-tracking redesign, live activities on the day of travel, and additional connection information. By the fourth quarter, **85% of customers used the United app on their day of travel**. More than half of customers who

experienced a cancellation in the fourth quarter effectively resolved their issue using self-service and automated tools.

- During 2025 United opened its fourth United ClubSM location in Denver and the second Club Fly location in Houston. Additionally, United re-opened a 50% larger United Polaris lounge at Chicago O'Hare and opened a new dining room at Newark's Polaris Lounge for an improved premium international travel experience.
- United brought TSA PreCheck Touchless ID to Washington Dulles and Houston and expanded usage in San Francisco and Chicago O'Hare in the fourth quarter for a more efficient customer experience. More than 3.5 million customers used this expedited feature in 2025.
- United upgraded the inflight entertainment experience for customers by adding more than 450 hours of Spotify audio and video content and award-winning, hit series from Apple TV for free on 150,000+ seatback screens. The airline achieved its highest inflight entertainment customer satisfaction scores among on-time passengers.

Source: [United Airlines Q4 and Full Year EPS Beat Wall Street Expectations, With Full Year EPS Up Year-Over-Year](#)

- What are United's main operational hubs?
 - Chicago O'Hare International Airport ("ORD")
 - Denver International Airport ("DEN")
 - George Bush Intercontinental Airport ("IAH")
 - Los Angeles International Airport ("LAX")
 - Newark Liberty International Airport ("EWR")
 - San Francisco International Airport ("SFO")
 - Washington Dulles International Airport ("IAD")

- A.B. Won Pat International Airport ("GUM")

Source: [United Airlines FY2025 10-K](#) (Strategy section).

- How do we increase throughput?
 - “Thirty-six percent of all travelers say the number one reason for their continued loyalty is an airline's proven track record for being on time. Gen Z’s loyalty is the most driven by on-time performance, with 63% remaining loyal to their preferred airline, followed by 52% of Millennials, 35% of Gen X and 25% of Baby Boomers.” (Source: [Loyalty & Disruption: The New Age of Travel | OAG North America Traveler Survey 2023](#))
 - “On-time performance also shapes booking habits. Eighty-two percent of all travelers said on-time performance affects the flight and/or airline they book with, assuming price and schedule options are relatively equal. Ninety-one percent of Gen Z are more inclined to pick the airline for on-time performance, compared to 87% of Millennials, 81% of Gen X and 77% of Baby Boomers.” (Source: [Loyalty & Disruption: The New Age of Travel | OAG North America Traveler Survey 2023](#))
 - “Our goal is to **make every flight a positive experience for our customers**. Our United Customer Commitment explains our specific service commitments so that we can continue a high level of performance and improve wherever possible. The commitment explains our policies in a clear, consistent and understandable fashion. We have detailed training programs and system enhancements to support our employees in meeting these commitments, and we measure how well we meet them.” (Source: [Our United Customer Commitment](#))
- What is our organization’s performance (vis-à-vis the competition)?

- The airline's ability to grow premium revenues by 6% while achieving negative unit cost growth demonstrates operational excellence in a challenging pricing environment. All seven of United's hubs generated profits during the quarter, underscoring the strength of its network strategy (Source: [United Airlines - Strategic Analysis and Outlook Report \(2026\)](#)).

Finance

- How are we performing?
 - United Airlines delivered solid Q3 2025 results that demonstrated the airline's **ability to recover from earlier operational disruptions and capitalize on improving demand trends** (Source: [United Airlines - Strategic Analysis and Outlook Report \(2026\)](#)).
 - The airline anticipates generating over \$3 billion in free cash flow for 2025, **maintaining approximately 50% conversion rate** as capital expenditures accelerate with fleet deliveries. Management projects this conversion rate will improve toward 75% as the fleet modernization program matures beyond 2030 (Source: [United Airlines - Strategic Analysis and Outlook Report \(2026\)](#)).

Customer Satisfaction

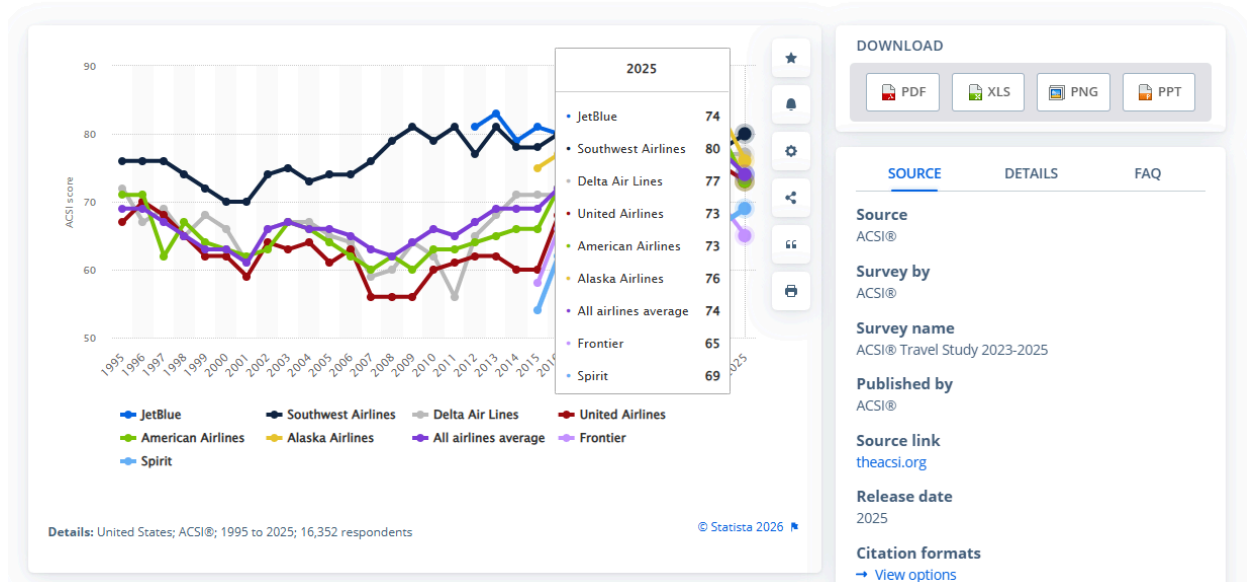
- "Our results are built on winning more and more brand-loyal customers — it's clear they get the most value flying United," said CEO Scott Kirby" (Source: [United Airlines Q4 and Full Year EPS Beat Wall Street Expectations, With Full Year EPS Up Year-Over-Year](#))

- “The government shutdown in November provided an opportunity to do the right thing by our customers and further build their trust. United offered all customers a full refund — even if their flights weren't canceled — and aggressively promoted that policy in customer communications including on a dedicated page on the corporate website, and within contact centers. Customers noticed: November was United's highest-ever monthly Net Promoter Score. Our customer-first policies, combined with the impact to bookings and costs, led to an approximately \$250 million impact to pre-tax earnings in the quarter.”
(Source: [United Airlines Q4 and Full Year EPS Beat Wall Street Expectations, With Full Year EPS Up Year-Over-Year](#))
- What are United’s customer satisfaction ratings relative to competitors?
 - **Delta significantly outperforms United in customer service in all passenger categories. Southwest is the top performer in the Economy/Basic Economy segment** (its only segment)

Source: [2025 North America Airline Satisfaction Study | JD Power](#) (Last updated 7/8/2025)

- United trails Southwest and Delta by 5+ customer satisfactions index scores (ACSI). Its current score is 4 points down from its all-time high score of 77 in 2023.

American customer satisfaction index scores for airlines in the United States from 1995 to 2025



Source: [Statista](#) (ACSI®. "American customer satisfaction index scores for airlines in the United States from 1995 to 2025." Chart. May 20, 2025. Statista. Accessed February 26, 2026.

<https://www-statista-com.proxy.library.nd.edu/statistics/194941/customer-satisfaction-with-us-airlines-since-1995/>)

- How does United rank compared to competitors in punctuality?
 - **Trails Delta in punctuality, but beats both Southwest and American, with 78.77% on time performance.**

Source: [The Most On-Time Airlines and Airports in North America in 2025 — Daily Passport](#)

PESTEL Analysis

Political The FAA is capping operations at several of United's core hubs, including ORD, EWR, and SFO, forcing United to trim its ambitious scheduling out of its core hubs.	Economic Volatile fuel prices and labor cost negotiations with flight crew unions threaten to increase variable costs for United, which is already investing large amounts in capital and R&D.
Social "United Next" is a premiumization strategy, and yet its customer satisfaction is below the industry average across all flight classes, damaging its brand value.	Technological In the past 3 years, United has ordered 650 new aircraft to replace older ones. According to CEO Scott Kirby, United is also 1 year away from replacing its legacy Unimatic software.
Environmental United's new Airbus A321neo and A321XLR aircraft offer a 30% lower fuel burn per seat than the aircraft they replace. United has also expanded the use of blended Sustainable Aviation fuel to six major hubs.	Legal Flight crews have legal limits regarding how many hours they can operate an aircraft. United also currently relies on its legacy software to calculate and submit critical information legally required for takeoff.

Work Plan

Current Assessment

United Airlines stands as one of the four primary leaders in the U.S. airline industry sector, operating the largest mainline fleet in the world with a route network that is the most comprehensive in North America⁶. In August 2025, United had the fourth largest domestic market share, trailing behind American, Delta, and Southwest Airlines, as depicted in the chart below⁷.

Airline	Domestic Market Share (Sept 2024 - Aug 2025)	Competitive Position
American Airlines	21%	Largest by market share
Delta Airlines	19-21%	Co-leader with premium focus
Southwest Airlines	18%	Low-cost carrier leader
United Airlines	16%	Fourth by share, but largest fleet globally

Despite being fourth in market share, “[t]he airline’s 5.7% domestic capacity growth in 2025 significantly exceeds competitors’ growth rates, positioning United to capture incremental market share through 2026”⁸. Moreover, United’s “ability to grow premium revenues by 6% while achieving negative unit cost growth demonstrates operational excellence in a challenging pricing environment”⁹.

⁶ [United Airlines - Strategic Analysis and Outlook Report \(2026\)](#)

⁷ [Ibid](#) (including chart)

⁸ [Ibid](#)

⁹ [Ibid](#)

In a January 2026 report, the airline boasted canceling flights at the lowest per-seat rate, logging 134 days without any cancellations, and saving over one million potential missed connections (a 42% improvement from 2024), all while flying the largest mainline schedule in company history¹⁰.

United's operational excellence drive is grounded in its commitment to "providing a level of service to our customers that makes us a leader in the airline industry [...] Our goal is to make every flight a positive experience for our customers"¹¹. This dedication was particularly noted during the November 2025 government shutdown, during which the company offered full refunds to all customers whose travel plans were affected – even if their flights were not cancelled. This move resulted in an approximately \$250 million impact to pre-tax earnings for the quarter, along with its highest monthly Net Promoter Score¹².

Problem in Context

Despite the November NPS spike, which is most likely a direct result of the full refunds offered to all customers with delayed or cancelled flights, United's customers are generally dissatisfied with the United experience. Amidst rising customer satisfaction rates in the domestic airline industry as a whole, United's American Customer Satisfaction Index (ACSI) score has fallen to 73 from an all-time high of 77 in 2023 (on a 0-100 scale), trailing competitors Southwest and Delta by over 4 points¹³. Moreover, the airline's customer satisfaction is below the segment average across all flight classes, placing it at a significant disadvantage in terms of customer retention, especially for a company that is currently pursuing a premiumization strategy¹⁴. This

¹⁰ [United Airlines Q4 and Full Year EPS Beat Wall Street Expectations. With Full Year EPS Up Year-Over-Year](#)

¹¹ [Our United Customer Commitment](#)

¹² [United Airlines Q4 and Full Year EPS Beat Wall Street Expectations. With Full Year EPS Up Year-Over-Year](#)

¹³ [ACSI®. "American customer satisfaction index scores for airlines in the United States from 1995 to 2025." Chart. May 20, 2025. Statista. Accessed February 26, 2026.](#)

¹⁴ [2025 North America Airline Satisfaction Study | JD Power](#)

decline compromises its mission to provide “a level of service to our customers that makes us a leader in the airline industry”¹⁵ and directly affects key external stakeholders, particularly premium business travelers and MileagePlus loyalty members, whose repeat purchase behavior disproportionately drives profitability.

Implementing solutions to boost United’s customer satisfaction requires an evaluation of its performance at its core hubs. United’s drive for maximum asset utilization at its core hubs such as Chicago O’Hare (ORD) and Newark Liberty (EWR) have compromised its on time performance at these airports. The delay problem at these airports have become so significant that the Federal Aviation Administration (FAA) has capped flight operations at ORD, EWR, and SFO, all of which are critical airports for United. In addition to the operational challenges brought about by these regulations, United’s on time performance struggles are directly hurting its customer satisfaction.

With each delay causing an average per passenger NPS impact of -10, United must pivot to an operationally sustainable strategy aimed at delay reduction and mitigation. Since the main drivers of this customer dissatisfaction among delays are untimely notifications (with an NPS impact of -90) and difficulty in rebooking (with an NPS impact of -45), United must implement solutions that identify delay likelihood ahead of time and provide fast, easy-to-use rebooking options for delayed flights.

Divergent Thinking and Hypothesis

United can improve customer satisfaction and retention by shifting its strategic focus from the pure peak efficiency of “United Next” to setting a standard of operational sustainability across its entire network, beginning with the core hubs that are currently struggling the most with on time performance. This new strategy relies on two main

¹⁵ [Our United Customer Commitment](#)

pillars: 1) proactively identifying and addressing the causes of delays, and 2) implementing solutions that help customers mitigate delays.

My initial research, which focused on the first pillar, found that United currently has a clearly defined delay identification strategy, despite the lack of descriptiveness found on the internet for competitive reasons. According to United CEO Scott Kirby, “we have better data to analyze what’s happening with delays and all the things that are happening [...] We took that off of the plate and told employees, “We want you to just do the right thing. You’re a team, work as a team”¹⁶. According to Kirby, United has “far better data than any airline in the world,”¹⁷ leveraging cameras and cutting-edge AI to identify the causes of delays. Moreover, Kirby claims that United will be replacing its 1997 Unimatic software in 2027¹⁸. Given the abundance of current projects aimed at delay identification and avoidance, I decided to pivot my recommendation toward the second pillar of operational sustainability.

While United can reduce delays by executing its current initiatives, it also operates in an industry where some delays are inevitable. With its core hubs being the busiest airports in the United States and inclement weather conditions in which aircraft cannot safely fly, United must empower its passengers to mitigate the effects of delays that cannot otherwise be avoided. United can improve its operational reliability and customer satisfaction by developing a feature on its app called *ClearPath*¹⁹ that preemptively flags the risk of a flight being delayed, notifies the flight’s passengers before they leave the airport, and proactively suggests alternative flights to and from the same airport which they can rebook in under a minute, free of charge. As this solution addresses the main drivers of customer dissatisfaction regarding delays, I

¹⁶ [An Interview with United CEO Scott Kirby About Tech Transformation – Stratechery by Ben Thompson](#)

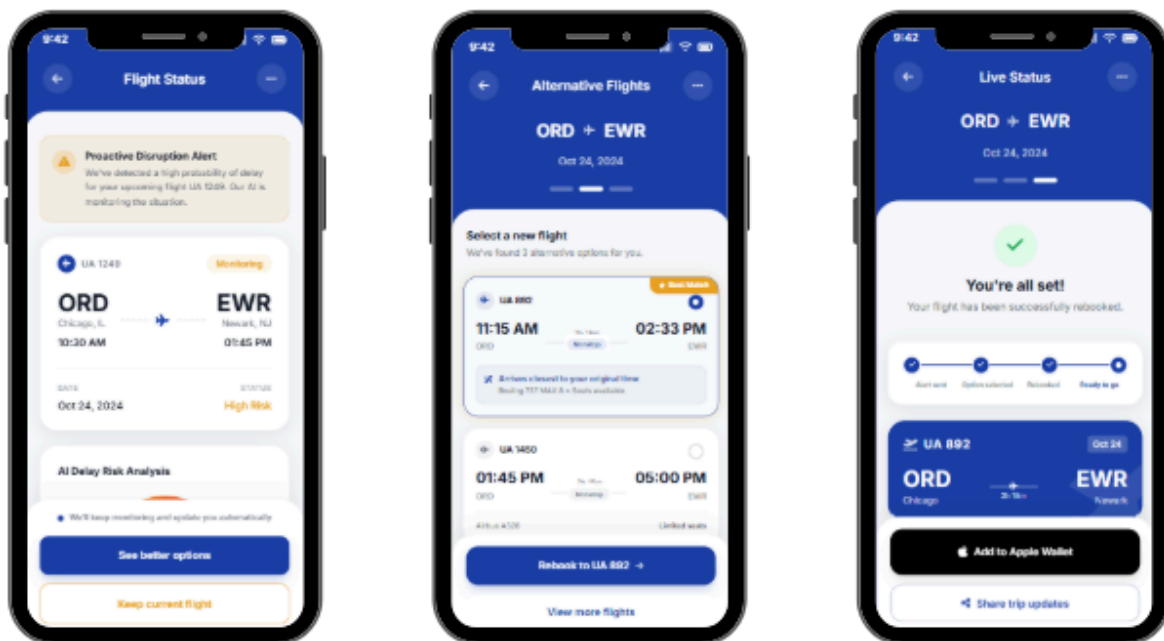
¹⁷ [Ibid](#)

¹⁸ [Ibid](#)

¹⁹ See page 10 for a mockup of *ClearPath* by United

expect it to have a per customer NPS impact of +10. Moreover, *ClearPath*'s AI-powered delay prediction and passenger alert systems will reduce costs for United by allowing crews to better prepare for impending delays and relieving its customer service line, yielding an estimated \$608 million in savings by 2029. By offering a proactive delay mitigation strategy, *ClearPath* will ultimately boost United's customer satisfaction, driving the operational sustainability United needs to capture incremental market share and close the gap with its main competitor Delta.

ClearPath Mockup



Issue Tree

Mutually Exclusive: "What Has to be True"	Collectively Exhaustive: Research Questions, Efforts, & Interviews	Timeline (Completion)
1. Operational Reality: United's ambitious scheduling at core hubs significant driver of airline costs and airport instability.	Research Question: What does the current state of United operations at core hubs look like in terms of flights offered, on time performance, and overall operational sustainability? Task: Extract and analyze flight delay data from the Bureau of Transportation Statistics (BTS) to identify United hubs that are causing the most flight delays Contact: Interview Henry Bird (Managing Director, IAD Hub) on the late aircraft ripple effect on flight delays at major airports.	Week 1: Feb. 28 - Mar. 13
2. Financial Justification: Implementing larger time buffers between flights and/or cutting flights from United's current schedule will leave revenue that United needs to pay for its massive CapEx costs on the table.	Research Question: Is the assumed cost of United's current scheduling higher than the cost of a 15–20 minute schedule buffer? Effort: Benchmark industry cost structures using IBISWorld. Contact: Interview Keely Meyercord (FP&A) to assess the most critical cost drivers for United and how to mitigate them.	Week 2: Apr. 12-18

3. Customer Loyalty Link: On-Time Performance (OTP) is the primary driver of customer satisfaction and long-term retention.	Research Question: Does a 1% increase in On Time Performance at major hubs correlate with a measurable increase in NPS for premium/business travelers? Effort: Identify the aspects of the customer experience that most affect airline NPS, as well as the specific operational areas where United's customer satisfaction is the lowest. Contact: Reach out to JD Power, asking if they are willing to provide the data behind their published study or more details into the breakdown of the ACSI scores	Week 3: Mar. 9-22
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Research Archive

United Airlines Internal & Strategic Documents

- [United Airlines - Strategic Analysis and Outlook Report \(2026\)](#)
 - *Description:* A core document detailing United's market position, 5.7% domestic capacity growth, and financial recovery strategies.
- [Our United Customer Commitment](#)
 - *Description:* Outlines the airline's service goals and policies to ensure positive flight experiences and performance improvements.
- [United Airlines FY2025 10-K \(Strategy Section\)](#)
 - *Description:* The official annual SEC filing listing United's primary operational hubs, including ORD, DEN, IAH, LAX, EWR, SFO, IAD, and GUM.
- [United Adds 270 Boeing and Airbus Aircraft to Fleet \(Jun 29, 2021\)](#)
 - *Description:* Details the historic fleet expansion order that serves as a foundation for the "United Next" modernization plan.
- [United Airlines Q4 and Full Year EPS Beat Wall Street Expectations](#)
 - *Description:* Reports on record widebody departures, record low cancellation rates in 2025, and the \$250 million impact of customer-first policies during the government shutdown.

Industry Performance & Analytics

- [OST R | BTS | Transtats DatabaseInfo \(Airline Performance\)](#)
 - *Description:* The primary database for extracting and analyzing flight delay data to identify problematic hubs.
- [U.S. Passenger Carrier Delay Costs – Airlines For America](#)
 - *Description:* Provides the industry metric that flight delays cost airlines approximately \$100.07 per minute.
- [Loyalty & Disruption: The New Age of Travel | OAG North America Traveler Survey 2023](#)
 - *Description:* Analyzes how on-time performance (OTP) shapes booking habits and loyalty across different generations, specifically highlighting Gen Z's high focus on punctuality.

- [The Most On-Time Airlines and Airports in North America in 2025 – Daily Passport](#)
 - *Description:* A rankings report placing United's 2025 on-time performance at 78.77%.
- [An Interview with United CEO Scott Kirby – Stratechery by Ben Thompson](#)
 - *Description:* A discussion on United's use of AI and cameras for delay identification and the planned replacement of 1997 Unimatic software.

Customer Satisfaction Studies

- [2025 North America Airline Satisfaction Study | JD Power](#)
 - *Description:* A benchmark study used to evaluate United's performance in specific operational areas and its overall Net Promoter Score (NPS).
- [Statista \(ACSI® Airline Scores 1995 to 2025\)](#)
 - *Description:* Historical tracking showing United's ACSI score falling to 73 in 2025 from an all-time high of 77 in 2023.

Critical Reviews & News

- [Is United Airlines Facing Execution Risk? A 2026 Review](#)
 - *Description:* An analysis of the market capitalization and potential operational risks associated with United's rapid capacity growth.
- [United Airlines Expects to Hire 25,000 People by 2026 - NBC Bay Area](#)
 - *Description:* News coverage of the large-scale staffing increases required to support United's fleet expansion.